PhD Backwards Calendar

Political Science PhD - Penn State - Fall 2026 to Summer 2031

This calendar follows academic years from Fall through Summer. It is an ambitious working plan, not a fixed promise: departmental milestones follow the expected sequence but should be checked against the applicable graduate handbook and dual-title requirements. I want to keep the difference clear between milestones that I can actively pursue and publication or employment outcomes that also depend on outside decisions.

2026-2027 | First Year: Establishing a Foundation

I will apply for the PiCP research grant to support ongoing research, revise my Sabancı MA thesis into a journal manuscript, and aim to make it publication-ready by the end of the academic year. I will also refine the foreign occupation project by strengthening its theoretical framework, identification strategy, and empirical design. Alongside this work, I will build a GitHub portfolio that brings together academic research, reproducible datasets, computational methods, and personal software projects. My core objective is to complete first-year coursework successfully while strengthening my statistical and methodological foundations and preparing for the departmental written qualifying examination in Summer 2027. I also want to make the transition to life in the United States sustainable by protecting work-life balance, maintaining at least one regular hobby or recreational activity outside academia, and establishing consistent saving and investing habits, including an emergency fund.

2027-2028 | Second Year: Research Development and Academic Networking

I will complete the departmental oral qualifying examination in Fall 2027 and prioritize coursework in comparative politics, causal inference, and computational methodology, including relevant Social Data Analytics courses. I will aim for at least one revise-and-resubmit decision from a peer-reviewed journal, while recognizing that this is an ambitious target that depends on editorial and peer-review timelines. I will begin the Penn State MA thesis by finalizing the research question and theoretical framework, conducting a comprehensive literature review, identifying and collecting relevant data, establishing a feasible design and identification strategy, consulting faculty, and developing a thesis timeline. I will work toward defending it by Spring 2028. Subject to funding and feasibility, I will conduct fieldwork or archival research for the foreign occupation project, attend and ideally present at an academic conference, and aim to participate in an overseas conference. I will contribute to establishing the Sabancı Turkish Politics Lab, develop academic networks across the United States, Europe, and Türkiye, seek a short-term RAship or faculty collaboration, and purchase a car if it is financially feasible.

2028-2029 | Third Year: Independent Scholarship and Dissertation Preparation

I will complete all remaining Political Science and Social Data Analytics requirements and the departmental third-year research project. I will develop and defend a coherent dissertation proposal and prepare for the departmental oral comprehensive examination by Spring 2029. I will aim to publish one sole-authored article in a top-tier peer-reviewed journal, recognizing this as a stretch goal whose outcome depends on peer review and publication timelines. I will revise the completed Penn State MA thesis into a journal manuscript, use the initial ABD period to strengthen advanced methodological and computational skills while keeping dissertation development central, and continue expanding my GitHub portfolio with reproducible projects, original datasets, and academic or personal software tools. I will seek additional short-term RAships or collaborations that complement the dissertation and identify the larger theoretical contribution that connects my existing projects to it.

2029-2030 | Fourth Year: Dissertation Research and Publication Pipeline

I will consolidate completed and ongoing projects under a coherent theoretical theme that supports the dissertation and develop at least three publication-ready projects, preferably including an original data paper. I will aim to have at least one publication in a top-tier peer-reviewed journal while maintaining an active pipeline of submissions and R&Rs.; I will complete major dissertation data collection and make substantial progress on empirical analyses and chapters. I will work toward attending or presenting at five academic conferences cumulatively, preferably including two overseas conferences in Europe and Türkiye, while expanding networks across the United States, Europe, and Türkiye and seeking collaborations or externally funded projects. I will explore opportunities to teach independently in comparative politics, political economy, or quantitative methodology. I will also begin job-market preparation by identifying tenure-track and postdoctoral opportunities, selecting and developing a job-market paper, preparing an academic CV and research statement, building a teaching portfolio, discussing the expected timeline with potential referees and advisors, maintaining a professional website, and identifying relevant private-sector research and data-science paths.

2030-2031 | Fifth Year: Dissertation Completion and Job Market

I will prioritize completing and refining the dissertation so that it is ready for defense before graduation. By Summer 2030, I will aim to have a polished job-market paper, updated academic CV, research statement, teaching statement and portfolio, professional website, confirmed referees and letter arrangements, a preliminary list of target departments and postdoctoral fellowships, and a schedule for practicing job talks and interviews. I will apply strategically to tenure-track positions and postdoctoral fellowships in the United States, Europe, and Türkiye while also exploring relevant private-sector roles in data science, computational social science, and applied research. I will attend at least fifteen job talks, preferably ten academic and five private-sector or industry-oriented presentations, continue building professional networks, seek instructor-of-record opportunities if I have not already done so, and continue revising and submitting manuscripts without allowing them to delay dissertation completion. I will also build substantial financial reserves for relocation and the transition into professional employment.

2031 | Graduation and Career Transition

I will defend and submit the dissertation as early as reasonably possible, targeting graduation in Spring or Summer 2031. I will aim to secure a tenure-track position beginning in Fall 2031, preferably in the United States or Europe while remaining open to opportunities in Türkiye. If a suitable tenure-track opportunity is unavailable, I will seriously consider competitive postdoctoral fellowships or research-oriented private-sector positions. I will turn dissertation chapters into independent journal articles, build a longer-term research agenda that can support an independent academic career, and retain enough savings to cover relocation, housing deposits, and initial living costs in the next position.

Important dependencies: the Spring 2028 MA defense, Spring 2029 comprehensive examination, and Summer 2030 job-market preparation are linked milestones; a delay in one may shift the others. The 2027-2028 R&R; and 2028-2029 sole-authored top-journal publication remain stretch goals rather than minimum indicators of success.

Last revised: October 2026